



Microsoft Cortana

Learn how to take advantage of Cortana's multifaceted features

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MICROSOFT'S VIRTUAL ASSISTANT, CORTANA,

may not be as popular as the likes of Google Assistant and Siri but it is powerful nonetheless. Apart from basic searches, Cortana can also pull off a bunch of productivity tasks which can make your life easier such as alert you to upcoming meetings and events, searching your PC, telling you news, setting reminders, tracking packages and flights, and much more. Also, Cortana is one of the more natural sounding voice assistants we've heard and she is quite humorous and witty too! Also, after throwing in a funny punchline, Cortana tends to keep the conversation going by occasionally asking you questions back, simulating an actual conversation. Cortana is now also available on iPhones and Android phones. With that being said, here's a compila-

tion of a couple of tips and tricks for Cortana with a few entertaining Easter eggs thrown in as well.



CORTANA SKILLS

Cortana can probably do a lot more than you give it credit for. It can play music through services such as Spotify, play podcasts on TuneIn, and even control smart home devices. You can even integrate apps such as Netflix and Hulu with Cortana, so that you can search and play shows just by talking to the as-

sistant. Cortana can also be connected to Fitbit and can provide you information about how many steps you've taken in the day. You can find the entire list of all the third-party applications Cortana is compatible with on the Microsoft website. Microsoft has termed these actions 'Cortana Skills'. Microsoft also launched Cortana Skills Kit which allows developers to create personalised, smart experiences for Cortana by using the Microsoft Bot Framework, in order to bring speech capabilities to these skills.

In order to add skills, first open Cortana on your desktop and then click the 'Notebook' icon on the left side of the screen. Head over to the 'Manage Skills' tab. Here, you can link your accounts (Spotify, Skype, LinkedIn, etc) with Cortana so that the assistant will be able to perform tasks revolving around them. You can also find new skills in the 'Manage Skills' tab by clicking on the 'Discover more skills' button. Note that this won't be available if Microsoft Edge is not your default browser. Now, you can do things such as play music from your selected service, get reminded about LinkedIn meetings, use

voice commands to launch Netflix shows and more. Also note, some skills don't require you to manually add the skill to Cortana, such as launching Netflix. As long as you have the app and you have signed in, Cortana will be able to perform related tasks for you.



SEARCH MEDIA FILES BASED ON TIME

You can actually ask Cortana to search for specific media files on your PC or OneDrive

HAVE A GO AT THESE CORTANA EASTER EGGS

- Play a game of rock, paper and scissors
- What does Cortana mean?
- Where do you live?
- Hey Siri!/ OK Google
- Do an impression
- Talk like a pirate
- Do you speak Klingon?

from particular dates. For example, you can give a command such as 'search all pictures from the month of April' and all the related pictures will be shown. Additionally, you can specifically search for videos or music in

the same manner. So, you can give Cortana commands such as 'Search for music files added yesterday' or any specific date and it will do the same. Note that this feature doesn't work on smartphones, only on desktop.



Cortana users can access skills from all these services and apps